THE SUBJECT

The World’s Smallest Escape Room?

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What is *The Subject*?

- ***The Subject*** is an escape room game that seeks to take classic escape game tropes and minimise them to a smaller scale - the game takes place inside a small, dark box.
- The narrative is set in the near future, inside a secret military facility in Wales.
- It is designed for two players: Player One will be locked inside the box. Player Two has to help them escape. Players have to work together to solve the puzzles and find the code that will unlock the box.
- The experience features extreme time pressure - it designed to be completed in just 30 minutes.
- If players lose then Player One has to stay locked in the box (maybe).

Why this project?

I've always wanted to design an escape room. Unfortunately, I don't have the means to take over a warehouse for a week and deck it out in eccentric themed paraphernalia.

With this project I wanted to see whether I could take the escape room concept and shrink it as small as possible, whilst still retaining the central pillars of escape game design.

I also wanted to try and redefine what escape room games can be. I believe that current escape rooms are far too gentile; they've become something that groups of friends do for weekend giggles, or corporates do for team-building.

In reality being locked in a room should be an uncomfortable experience. I wanted my game to be one that you'll want to finish as soon as possible - not for points or pride, but for sheer physical necessity.

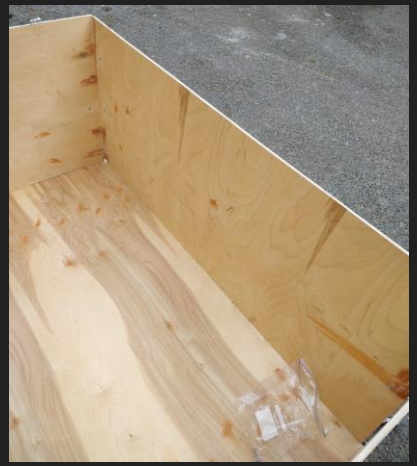
Small Fry - Previous ‘Smallest’ Escape Rooms

It would be wrong to try to build the world’s smallest escape room without referring to previous efforts, both from 2018:

The World’s Smallest Escape Room (2018)
Houdini Escapes
As part of the Portsmouth Festivities

World’s Smallest Escape Room (2018)
Jelle De Bruijn/Leo van der Veen

The previous rooms are pretty small, right? Think again.



- ❑ Dimensions: 120cm x 70cm x 50cm.
- ❑ 8mm plywood walls, metal brackets.
- ❑ No interior light source.
- ❑ Collapsible for easy(ish) transportation.

Building the Box

I always knew I wanted to make the room out of a shipping crate: it’s a visual that ties in with the story and elements of the puzzles (transportation) and would also save me having to build from scratch (incompatible with my limited budget).

I was going to buy a no nail plywood box from a packaging company, but I ended up sourcing an old sturdier shipping crate from a budget furniture warehouse in Brixton. Unfortunately it was rather cumbersome and I couldn’t quite get it into my flat.

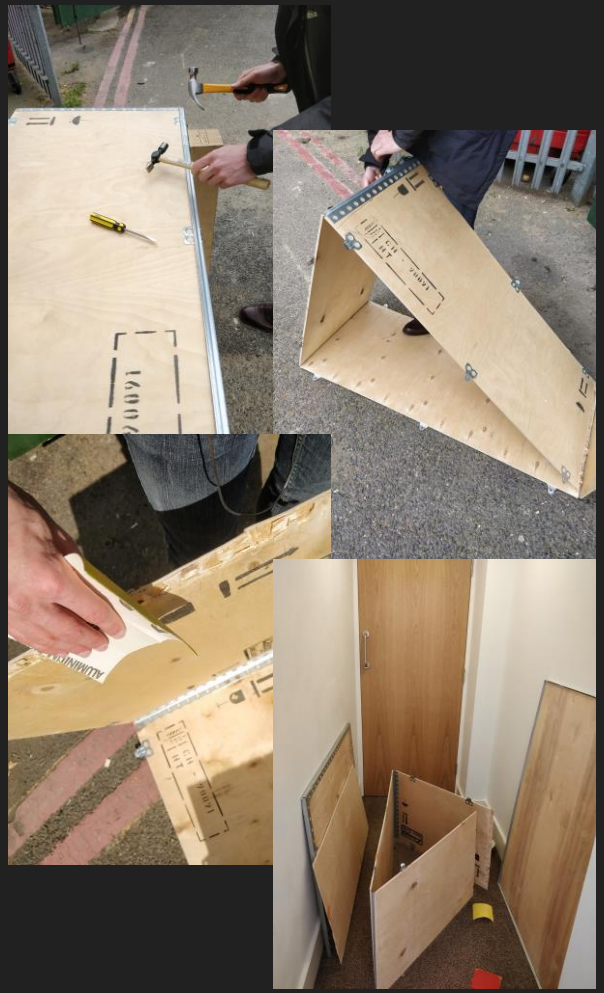
EXPECTATION

REALITY

Building the Box

The frame of the box was not collapsible due to the heavy metal stapled joints. Luckily I have a friend who is rather handy with a hammer. We managed to lever away one of the metal joints, and bend the others to flat-pack the box and store it.

The cracks from where the joint was needed to be filled, and then I attached brackets to the detached side that easily be screwed or unscrewed when assembling/disassembling the box.



Building the Box

With more time (and more filler) the cracked edges could have been made more polished, but I was happy to ensure everything was sturdy enough and move on. Similarly, the brackets, whilst not being the most attractive solution, did the job that was required.

To finish the box I used masking tape to cut out the lettering, and the spray-painted the box. The lettering was probably the most arduous part, largely because I had to do this finicky task in a pub car-park behind my flat…

All in all, given the limits imposed by time, budget, and my own carpentry abilities, I'm quite pleased with the final product.

Designing the Game - Design Values

Claustrophobia – I want Player One to feel trapped, uncomfortable, and scared. I want that desperation to impact upon their ability to parse information and solve puzzles.

Cooperation – The only way that Player One can escape from the box is by cooperating with Player Two. Think *Keep Talking and Nobody Explodes* but with more physicality and higher stakes. The game leans on an asymmetrical information space between the two players, with communication requirements built into every puzzle.

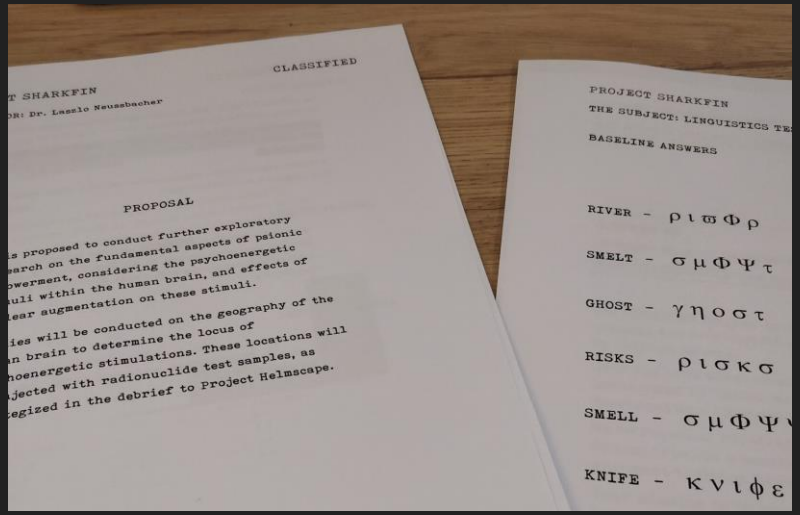
Emergent Narrative – Players will naturally learn more about the backstory of their characters by reading the materials required to solve the puzzles. The story is two-sided, so each player will learn things about the world the game is set in that are unique to their experience of the game.

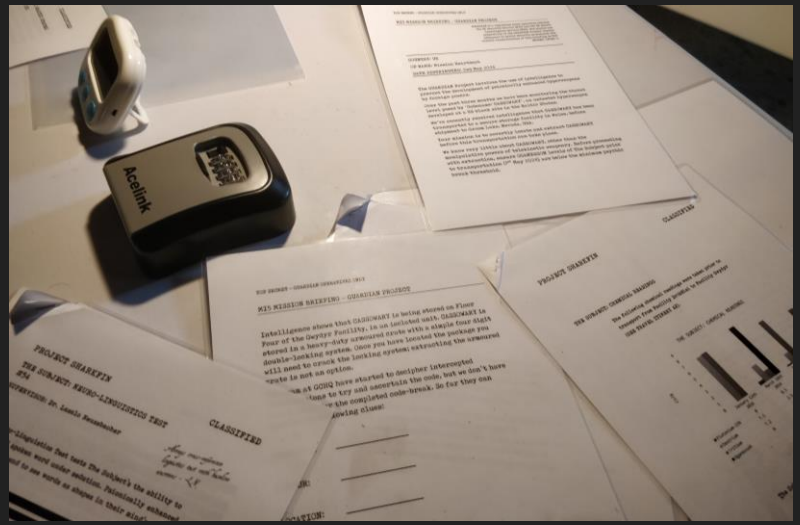
Designing the Game - Puzzles

I wanted the gameplay to be focused on cooperation between the two players; it’s impossible to solve a puzzle without sharing information. I used the game’s first puzzle to establish this play requirement, and then continued this logic in the other three puzzles.

I also wanted the puzzles to lead the players into the story. A particular example of this is the final puzzle, which requires the player in the box to look over every message that is plastered on their walls. All the puzzles are embedded within the narrative.

The one big problem with this design of room is the lack of feedback for the puzzles. Players only discover if they’ve solved the puzzles by putting all the answers into the lockbox and seeing if it opens. There’s nothing to give puzzle-by-puzzle feedback. This is something I’d like to improve.





Left: Player Two's game materials, designed to look and read like military intelligence documents.
Below: Player One's game materials, laid out on the walls of the box and written to reflect the diminishing hope of the caged man.

Designing the Game - Narrative

For the game's story, I was inspired by the horrifying evils of wartime human experimentation, as well as CIA programmes such as MKUltra.

Player One is The Subject, a prisoner of war locked up in a black site laboratory and experimented on by nefarious scientists as they attempt to create a super-weapon out of a human. Player Two is a Secret Services operative who wants to prevent this experimentation by freeing The Subject.

During the experience, Player Two can learn more about The Subject, where they came from, and what the purposes of the experiments conducted on them are. Player One's story is focused on delving into the psyche of The Subject during their ordeal.

The Future?

There are two main aspects of the experience that I'd like to expand on in the future:

1. The Box - Whilst the box I have at the moment is fine for a low-budget prototype, if I were to take this idea further I would want to build a custom box from scratch that is significantly easier to disassemble and store, and isn't quite so shabby on the inside.

2. The Narrative - I really like the story that I've crafted for this game, but with more time I would like to go further with the world-building, particularly for Player One's side of the story (The Subject). The sheer quantity of the writing required made it difficult this time round, but I really like the idea of plastering all the walls with The Subject's own words. This would give a deeper sense of what they're feeling, but also act as a shroud to greater hide some of the information required to solve the puzzles.